PERSONAL STATEMENT

Shota Kakiuchi | Recruit Holdings – New Graduate Application

The moment I remember most from my senior-year engineering project was not watching our rocket launch. It was looking at the flight data afterward and realizing that the airbrakes we had spent months developing had not activated as planned.

At George Washington University, I helped lead a capstone project to build a high-powered rocket with an active airbrake system. Instead of simply letting the rocket follow its natural trajectory, our goal was to use sensors, software, and mechanical hardware to control its maximum altitude. I was responsible for developing the flight computer and control software, bringing together sensors, data collection, and the mechanism that would deploy the airbrakes.

I was excited by the idea because it required us to turn things we had learned in class into a real, functioning system. On paper, we could model the physics and predict how the rocket should behave. In reality, every decision came with complications. Sensors produced noisy data, electronics had to survive demanding conditions, and even a small error in our software could affect the entire flight.

During an early flight test, our control system did not transition into the state needed to activate the airbrakes. It was frustrating, especially after all the time our team had spent designing, machining, programming, and testing. But the experience changed how I approached engineering. Rather than focusing only on the result, I learned to break a problem down, examine the data, challenge my assumptions, and work with teammates to find what we had missed. We refined the system and continued testing. By the end of the project, we had demonstrated the potential of active altitude control, and our team received our department's best capstone project award.

What made that experience especially meaningful was the ownership. No one could give us a complete set of instructions. We had to make decisions with imperfect information, learn skills outside our comfort zones, and trust each other to deliver. I realized that this is the kind of environment where I do my best work: when I am given a difficult problem, the freedom to explore it, and the responsibility to turn an idea into something real.

I carried that mindset into my internships. At Medtronic, I worked on manufacturing and operational improvements and saw how small changes to a process could create meaningful results at scale. At Apple Japan, I worked with precision optical measurement technology, where I had to learn an unfamiliar technical field, design experiments, and investigate sources of measurement variation. Although the industries were different, I enjoyed the same fundamental challenge: understanding why something works the way it does, then finding a better way to do it.

My experience at Deloitte also gave me another perspective. Working on technology and risk-related projects showed me that a strong technical solution is not enough on its own. It also has to make sense for the people, organizations, and processes that depend on it. As someone who speaks both English and Japanese, I have especially enjoyed working across different teams and perspectives.

I am now pursuing a master's degree in Mechanical Engineering at Columbia University, but I do not see my future as limited to one engineering discipline. I want to work on problems where technology, business, and people intersect, and where a small improvement can grow into a much larger impact. That is part of what attracts me to Recruit: its emphasis on giving people ownership, backing their passion, and creating value through new ideas.

My rocket project taught me that I am most motivated not by having all the answers, but by being responsible for finding them. I hope to keep taking on challenges that push me to learn quickly, collaborate with others, and build something that makes a real difference.